

PARAGRAPHING

How ideas are grouped and broken up



1 What is it?

Paragraphing

Paragraphing is how a writer **groups or breaks up** ideas into separate blocks of text — the length and structure of paragraphs shapes how information lands.

one idea = one paragraph (usually)

2 See it in action

A single-line paragraph

He was gone. A whole paragraph, just three words, for maximum impact.

A long, dense paragraph

Packed with detail and description, slowing the reader and building a full picture.

Paragraph breaks for tension

Breaking a sentence across paragraphs can create a dramatic pause before a reveal.

Topic shift

A new paragraph signals a new idea — a change of speaker, place, or focus.



Good spot!

Notice when a paragraph is **unusually short** compared to the ones around it — that's almost always a deliberate structural choice for emphasis.

FUN FACT

A famous piece of writing advice is "if in doubt, cut it out and start a new paragraph" — professional editors often break long paragraphs specifically to give the reader's eye (and brain) a rest.

3 Why writers use it

Paragraphing helps writers: organise ideas clearly for the reader, control pacing and emphasis (a short paragraph after long ones stands out), and signal shifts in topic, time, or speaker.

A single-sentence paragraph is one of the most dramatic structural tools available — because it breaks the expected pattern, it forces the reader to pause and pay extra attention.

4 Where you'll spot it

Newspaper articles

Journalists use short paragraphs deliberately, so key facts land clearly and are easy to skim.

Literary fiction

A single dramatic one-line paragraph is a favourite technique for a shocking reveal.



Watch out!

Don't just note THAT a paragraph is short or long — always explain the EFFECT: a short paragraph draws attention, a long one can build atmosphere or bury a detail in more text.



Keep going!

Ask what **new idea, speaker, or moment** triggers each new paragraph — paragraph breaks are rarely random.

5 Quick recap

Groups or breaks up ideas

Length affects emphasis

Signals topic or focus shifts



Mfalme says...

Try writing a short paragraph of build-up, then a single-sentence paragraph as the punchline — feel how much weight that short one carries.